

114th International Labour Conference



For Prelims: International Labour Conference , Code on Wages, 2019 , Industrial Relations Code, 2020 , Code on Social Security, 2020 , Occupational Safety, Health and Working Conditions (OSH) Code, 2020 , Gig workers , National Career Service (NCS)

For Mains: Labour Reforms and Labour Codes in India, Role of ILO and International Labour Conference

Source: TH

Why in News?

The Union Minister of State for Labour and Employment led the Indian delegation at the 114th **International Labour Conference (ILC)** in Geneva, where India showcased its labour reforms, expanding social protection initiatives, and **Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI)**.

- However, despite the enactment of the **four Labour Codes** , concerns persist over weak implementation, inadequate enforcement, and limited coverage of informal and **gig workers** , leaving a significant section of the workforce vulnerable.

Summary

- India showcased its labour reforms, expanding social protection and Digital Public Infrastructure at the 114th International Labour Conference (ILC), highlighting improved employment indicators and wider social security coverage through initiatives such as the e-Shram Portal and Labour Codes.
- Despite these achievements, concerns remain over weak implementation of Labour Codes, inadequate protection for gig and informal workers, wage stagnation, limited collective bargaining rights, and the need for stronger social security and labour welfare mechanisms.

What are the Key Highlights of India's Address at the 114th ILC?

- **Consolidation of Labour Laws:** India highlighted its wide-ranging labour reforms, guided by the

principle of **“Antyodaya”** (uplifting the weakest), which consolidated 29 archaic Central Labour Laws into **four modern Labour Codes** to simplify compliance and strengthen welfare.

- **Surge in Employment and Employability Metrics:**

- **Youth Employability:** Increased from 34% in 2014 to over 56% in 2025.
- **Unemployment Rate:** Dropped significantly from 6% (in 2017) to 3.1% in 2025.
- **Women’s Workforce Participation:** Surged from 22% to 38.8%.

- **Massive Expansion of Social Security:** India apprised the **International Labour Organization (ILO)** that social protection coverage has expanded from **19% in 2015 to 64.3% in 2025**.

- According to ILO estimates, it now covers around **1,001 million (1 billion) people** .

- **Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) as Soft Power:** The **National Career Service Portal** and the **e-Shram Portal** were showcased as scalable Digital Public Goods.

- During bilateral meetings with **Rwanda and Sri Lanka** , India extended technical assistance for developing similar digital platforms for workforce planning and formalisation.

- **International Labour Mobility:** India emphasized a whole-of-government approach to link domestic skilling with global employment opportunities, including an ongoing feasibility study with the ILO to develop an **international reference classification of occupations** .

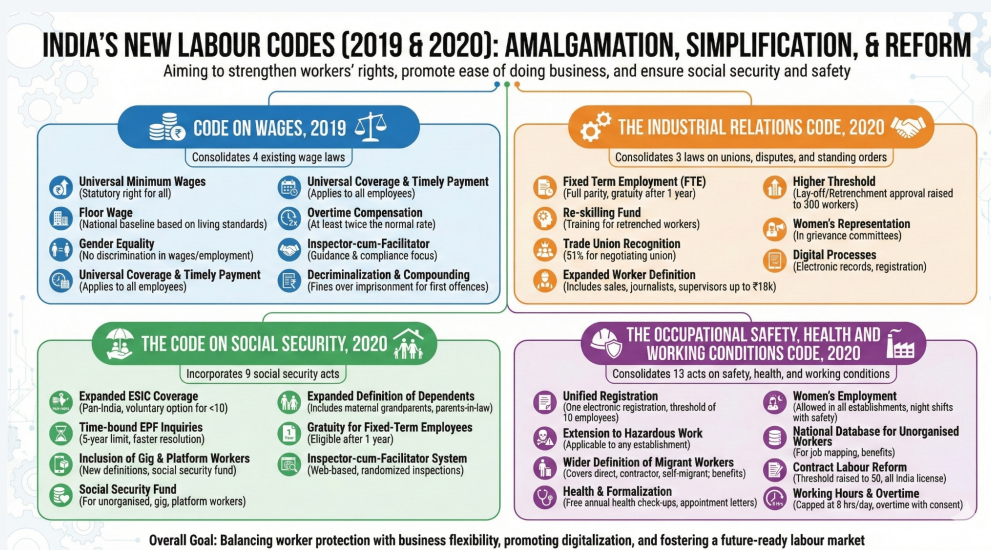
- **New Initiatives:** Highlighted the launch of the **Pradhan Mantri Viksit Bharat Rozgar Yojana** to promote rapid employment generation.

International Labour Conference (ILC)

- **About :** The **International Labour Conference (ILC)** is the supreme decision-making and deliberative body of the **International Labour Organization (ILO)** , a specialized agency of the **United Nations**.
 - Often referred to as the "**international parliament of labour**," the ILC meets annually typically in June in Geneva, Switzerland to set global labour standards, discuss key world-of-work issues, and shape the broad policies of the ILO.
- **Unique Tripartite Structure:** Unlike most international bodies where only governments vote, the **ILC follows a tripartite structure**.
 - Each member state sends **two government delegates, one employer delegate, and one worker delegate** , all with independent voting rights.
 - This allows employers and workers to vote differently from their governments, ensuring direct representation of labour and industry interests in international labour standards.

New Labour Codes

- **Code on Wages, 2019:** Universalizes the provision of minimum wages and timely payment of wages to all employees across both organized and unorganized sectors.
- **Industrial Relations Code, 2020:** Streamlines dispute resolution, alters trade union recognition rules, and modifies conditions for layoffs, retrenchment, and closures.
- **Code on Social Security, 2020:** Extends the reach of the **ESIC (Employees' State Insurance Corporation)** and **EPFO (Employees' Provident Fund Organisation)**.
 - It is the first legal framework in India to theoretically bring **gig workers and platform workers** into the social security net.
- **Occupational Safety, Health and Working Conditions (OSH) Code, 2020:** Regulates health and safety conditions, explicitly addressing inter-state migrant workers and contract labourers.



Why is the Indian Workforce Still Vulnerable

Despite the New Labour Reforms?

- **Gig Workers in a Legal Grey Zone:** While the Code on Social Security, 2020 mentions gig and platform workers, it deliberately stops short of recognizing them as standard **"employees."**
 - Without a formal employer-employee relationship, they are excluded from the **Industrial Relations Code, 2020 and the OSH Code, 2020**, depriving them of minimum wage guarantees and workplace safety rights.
- **Algorithmic Tyranny:** Delivery and logistics workers face a completely automated workplace. Automated ratings, absolute performance metrics, and opaque dark-store allocation software dictate daily earnings and penalties without any avenue for human recourse or dispute resolution.
 - Platform aggregators frequently implement unilateral changes to piece-rate wage structures, systematically reducing per-delivery or per-ride base payouts to cut operational overheads.
- **Higher Thresholds for 'Hire and Fire':** The **Industrial Relations Code, 2020** increased the threshold for establishments to seek prior government permission before closure, lay-offs, or retrenchment from 100 to **300 workers**.
 - This creates a highly flexible 'hire and fire' regime, leaving millions of workers in MSMEs without job security.
- **Exploitation of Working Hour "Flexibility":** The OSH Code, 2020 enforces a **macroscopic 48-hour work week**, it leaves daily shift limits, mandatory rest intervals, and spread-over caps ambiguous.
 - This regulatory grey area has enabled employers to **enforce grueling 12-hour shifts** under the pretext of transitioning to a compressed 4-day workweek, frequently bypassing mandatory overtime premiums.
- **Dilution of Collective Bargaining:** The new rules raise the threshold for recognizing trade unions as sole negotiating agents.
 - A union now requires the support of 51% of workers on the muster roll, making it significantly harder for unorganised and contract workers to unionize and negotiate collectively.
 - The code mandates a strict **60-day notice period** before executing a strike and entirely bans strikes during active conciliation proceedings, effectively shrinking the constitutional and legal scope for industrial action.
- **Exclusionary Applicability of OSH:** The OSH Code, 2020 applies primarily to establishments with 10 or more workers.
 - This automatically excludes the vast majority of India's informal setups and micro-enterprises from basic safety mandates and inspections.
- **Translation of Digital Data into Tangible Benefits:** While the e-Shram portal is a monumental achievement in data collection (registering millions of unorganized workers), translating this database into actual, last-mile welfare benefits (like pensions, healthcare, and debt relief) remains deeply inconsistent across States.
- **Inflation-Driven Wage Stagnation:** The minimum wage system in India operates on a dual-component architecture consisting of a **base wage** (revised every five years) and a **Variable Dearness Allowance (VDA)** linked to the **Consumer Price Index for Industrial Workers (CPI-IW)**, updated twice a year.
 - Between 2021 and 2026, the CPI-IW surged by nearly **25%**. While states have adjusted the inflation-linked VDA, they have chronically delayed updating the fundamental base wage, leading to severe real-wage erosion.
- **Socio-Economic Pressures on Migrant Labour:** Factory workers majority of whom are inter-state migrants face a localized cost-of-living crisis.

- Surging urban room rents, volatile food inflation, and forced reliance on informal, black-market essentials (such as heavily inflated parallel-market LPG cylinders) have completely outpaced nominal wage growth.

What Measures are Needed to Strengthen Labour Welfare?

- **Defining a New Worker Category:** India must move past the binary of "employee" vs. "independent contractor." Drawing inspiration from the **EU's Platform Work Directive**, India should legally define a 'Dependent Contractor' or 'Platform Worker' category that guarantees a minimum base pay (irrespective of piece-rate fluctuations).
- **Adopt the Rajasthan Model:** Replicate key features of the **Rajasthan Platform-Based Gig Workers Act, 2023**, including a welfare board with gig worker representation and welfare cess collection from platform transactions.
- **Promote Digital Compliance:** Replace inspector-centric enforcement with data-driven monitoring through digital wage payments and electronic employment records.
- **Actionable Convergence of e-Shram:** The monumental success of the *e-Shram* database must now be leveraged for active welfare delivery.
 - The portal must be algorithmically linked with the **One Nation One Ration Card (ONORC)**, **Ayushman Bharat**, and **PM-SYM** to instantly trigger targeted financial relief, housing benefits, and healthcare access for migrant workers during global supply chain shocks or pandemics.
- **Reviving the Indian Labour Conference:** The domestic Indian Labour Conference (ILC) must be actively convened to foster genuine dialogue between the State, employer associations, and trade unions.
 - Ensuring that the voices of unorganized and contract workers are represented at the negotiating table will mitigate industrial friction before it erupts into protests.

Conclusion

India's labour reforms through the four Labour Codes are a major step toward improving competitiveness and economic growth. However, their success depends on extending social security, fair wages, and dignified working conditions to the vast informal and gig workforce. Achieving **Viksit Bharat 2047** requires balancing labour market flexibility with worker welfare, ensuring that economic progress translates into inclusive and equitable development.

Drishti Mains Question:

Critically examine whether the four Labour Codes strike an appropriate balance between labour market flexibility and workers' rights.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the International Labour Conference (ILC)?

The ILC is the highest decision-making body of the International Labour Organization (ILO), meeting annually in Geneva to formulate international labour standards and policies.

2. What is unique about the ILC's tripartite structure?

Each member state is represented by government, employer, and worker delegates with independent voting rights, ensuring balanced representation of labour and industry interests.

3. What are the four Labour Codes enacted by India?

India consolidated 29 labour laws into four codes: Code on Wages (2019), Industrial Relations Code (2020), Social Security Code (2020), and OSH Code (2020).

4. Why do gig workers remain vulnerable despite the Social Security Code, 2020?

Gig workers are recognized for social security purposes but are not classified as employees, limiting access to minimum wages, collective bargaining rights, and workplace protections.

5. What is the significance of the e-Shram Portal?

The e-Shram Portal is a national database of unorganized workers that facilitates targeted welfare delivery, social security coverage, and labour market formalization.

6. What is the Rajasthan Platform-Based Gig Workers Act, 2023?

It is India's first dedicated law for gig workers, establishing a welfare board, worker registration mechanism, and welfare cess on digital platforms.

[Watch Video on YouTube: [▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/vnI59vez5mE](https://www.youtube.com/embed/vnI59vez5mE)]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. In India, which one of the following compiles information on industrial disputes, closures, retrenchments and lay-offs in factories employing workers? (2022)

- (a) Central Statistics Office
- (b) Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade
- (c) Labour Bureau
- (d) National Technical Manpower Information System

Ans: (c)

Mains

Q. Discuss the merits and demerits of the four 'Labour Codes' in the context of labour market reforms in India. What has been the progress so far in this regard? (2024)

Credit Guarantee Scheme for Microfinance Institutions-2.0 (CGSMFI-2.0)



Source: PIB

Why in News?

The **Government of India** has approved the **extension of the CGSMFI-2.0 scheme** till **31st August 2026** or until guarantees for an amount of ₹20,000 crore are issued, whichever is earlier.

- The **maximum loan limit for large NBFC -MFIs/ MFIs** under the scheme has been increased from **₹300 crore to ₹1,000 crore** , within the overall ceiling of **20% of their Assets under Management (AUM)** .
- As of now, loans totalling **₹770 crore** have already been sanctioned under CGSMFI-2.0.

What is CGSMFI-2.0?

- CGSMFI-2.0 is a **government-backed credit guarantee scheme launched in March 2026** to provide guarantee coverage to **Member Lending Institutions (MLIs)** for loans extended to NBFC-MFIs and MFIs, which in turn use the funds for on-lending to eligible small borrowers under RBI's microfinance definition.
- Under it, guarantee coverage is linked to the size of the MFI, with **small MFIs receiving 80%, medium MFIs 75%, and large MFIs 70%** of the amount in default, replacing the earlier flat 75% coverage to better support smaller institutions.
- MFIs are classified based on **Assets Under Management (AUM)** into **small (less than ₹500 crore), medium (₹500 crore to less than ₹2,000 crore), and large (₹2,000 crore or more)** .
 - MLIs must ensure that at least 5% of total loans go to small MFIs and 10% to medium MFIs to promote equitable credit distribution.
- Loan limits are linked to the MFI's AUM, with **maximum caps of ₹100 crore for small MFIs, ₹200 crore for medium MFIs, and ₹300 crore for large MFIs**, and loans must be disbursed within three months, with a maximum tenure of three years, including a one-year moratorium.
- The scheme operates through an **automatic approval mechanism at National Credit Guarantee Trustee Company Ltd (NCGTC)**, and funds must be used exclusively for incremental lending to eligible borrowers, ensuring that CGSMFI-2.0 directly increases credit flow to underserved segments.



Microfinance Institutions

- **About: Microfinance Institutions (MFIs)** are financial intermediaries that provide **small loans (microcredit) and financial services** to low-income households, primarily in rural and semi-urban areas.
 - They aim to **promote financial inclusion**, livelihood development, and economic empowerment of poor and marginalized populations who lack access to formal banking.
 - MFIs operate as **NBFC-MFIs (Non-Banking Financial Companies - Microfinance Institutions)** or **cooperative/NGO-led MFIs**.
- **Key Features:**
 - **Target Borrowers:** Small, low-income households, often women, who lack access to formal banking.
 - **Loan Size:** Typically ranges from ₹5,000 to ₹1,00,000 for income-generating activities or emergencies.
 - **Collateral:** Usually **no collateral or very minimal**, relying on group lending or peer pressure mechanisms.
 - **Delivery Models:**
 - **Joint Liability Group (JLG)** : Borrowers form groups; repayment responsibility shared.
 - **Self-Help Groups (SHGs)** : Community-based microfinance model linked with banks.
- **Regulatory Framework:**
 - **Reserve Bank of India (RBI)** : Regulates NBFC-MFIs, defines **eligibility criteria, loan size, interest rate caps, and prudential norms**.
 - **National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development (NABARD)** : Provides refinance support and monitors SHG-linked microfinance.

Microfinance Institutions (MFIs)

About MFIs

- Provides financial services & small-value loans
- **Targets** – Low-income households, small businesses, & entrepreneurs in rural & urban areas
- Maximum annual income criteria – **Rs 3 lakh** (for collateral-free microloans)

Evolution of Microfinance Sector

- **Initial Period (1974–1984):**
 - Shri Mahila Sewa Sahakari Bank established for women
 - NABARD promoted SHG linkage
- **Change Period (2002–2008):**
 - Unsecured lending norms for SHGs were aligned with secured loans
 - RBI included microfinance in the priority sector
- **Growth and Crisis (2007–2010):**
 - Private equity investments → Rapid MFI growth
 - Microfinance Institutions Network (MFIN) formed
- **Consolidation and Maturity (2011–2015):**
 - Malegam Committee (2011) recommended regulatory changes
 - New Category of NBFCs – Non Banking Financial Company-Micro Finance Institutions (NBFC-MFIs)
 - Universal banking license to Bandhan Bank (largest microlender) by RBI (2014)
 - MUDRA Bank launched (2015)



MFIs in India are regulated by the RBI through the NBFC-MFIs framework 2014.

Business Models

- **Self Help Groups (SHGs):**
 - Informal groups (10-20 members) saving together & accessing credit
 - Linked to banks through the SHG-Bank Linkage Programme
- **Microfinance Institutions (MFIs):**
 - Offer micro-credit & financial services
 - Loans through Joint Lending Groups (JLGs) of 4-10 members



Types of MFIs

- **NGO-MFIs** (under Society Registration Act 1860 or Indian Trust Act 1880)
- **Co-operative Societies**
- **Section 8 Companies** (under Companies Act, 2013)
- **NBFC-MFIs** (accounts for 80% of microfinance market)



Benefits

- Digitization and financial inclusion
- Self-sufficiency (entrepreneurship and improved livelihoods)
- Steady income (assets building)
- Women entrepreneurship



Challenges of MFIs	Way Forward
High Interest Rates	Improve regulatory oversight and encourage interest rate caps
Over-Indebtedness of Borrowers	Strengthen credit risk assessment and promote financial literacy
Dependency on External Funding	Diversify funding sources through partnerships and capital markets
Low Financial Literacy Among Borrowers	Promoting financial education programs/campaigns



Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is CGSMFI-2.0?

CGSMFI-2.0 (Credit Guarantee Scheme for Microfinance Institutions) provides **credit guarantee cover** to banks/financial institutions for loans extended to NBFC-MFIs and MFIs for on-lending to small borrowers.

2. Who are eligible borrowers under CGSMFI-2.0?

Existing or new **small borrowers** as per RBI's regulatory definition of microfinance.

3. What is the guarantee coverage under the scheme?

Small NBFC-MFIs/MFIs: 80% of amount in default.

4. Medium NBFC-MFIs/MFIs: 75% of amount in default.

Large NBFC-MFIs/MFIs: 70% of amount in default.

5. What is the maximum loan limit for NBFC-MFIs/MFIs?

Large NBFC-MFIs/MFIs: **₹1,000 crore** (increased from ₹300 crore), within **20% of AUM**.

[Watch Video on YouTube:

▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/PA5_WR_I-3U

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UPSC Civil Services Examination - Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. Consider the following statements: [2023]

1. The Self-Help Group (SHG) programme was originally initiated by the State Bank of India by providing microcredit to the financially deprived.
2. In an SHG, all members of a group take responsibility for a loan that an individual member takes.
3. The Regional Rural Banks and Scheduled Commercial Banks support SHGs.

How many of the above statements are correct?

- | | |
|--------------|-------------|
| a) Only one | b) Only two |
| c) All three | d) None |

Ans: (b)

Mains

Q. Can the vicious cycle of gender inequality, poverty and malnutrition be broken through microfinancing of women SHGs? Explain with examples. **(2021)**

Resettlement Census Notified for Great Nicobar Project



Source: [TH](#)

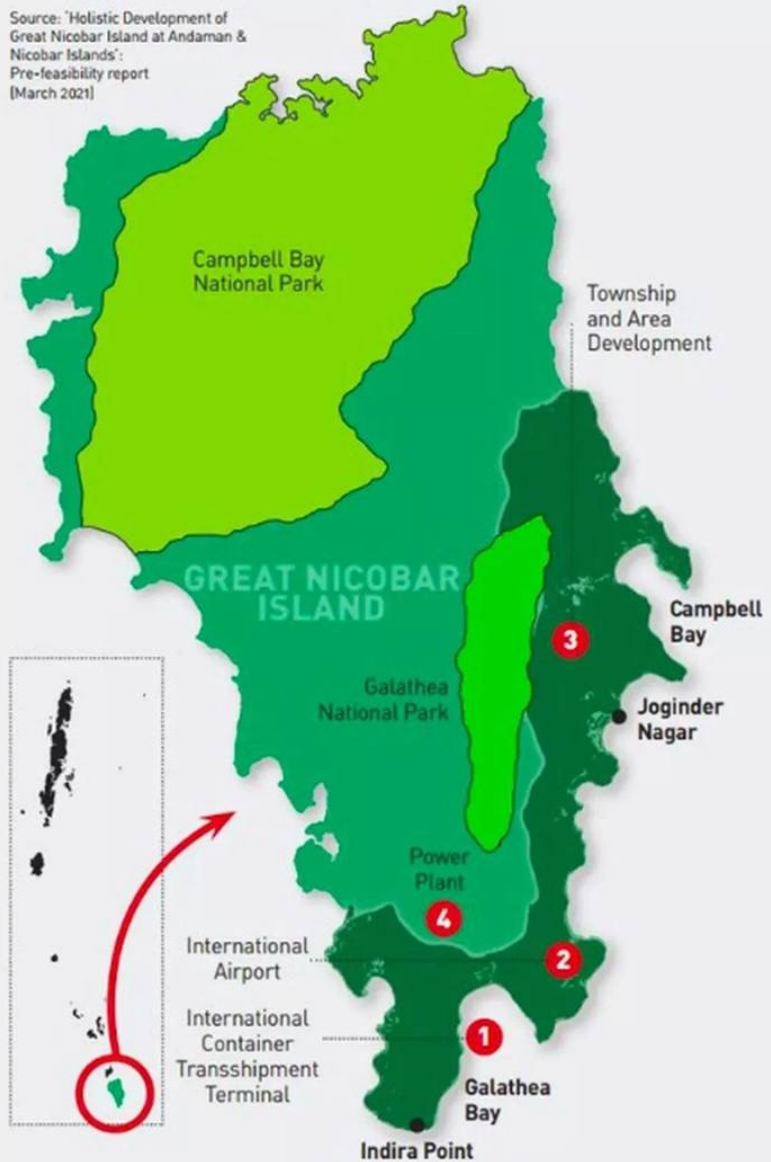
Recently, the Andaman and Nicobar Islands administration notified the beginning of the **rehabilitation and resettlement census** in **Great Nicobar Island** for the trunk infrastructure component of the mega-infrastructure project.

- **R&R Census:** The rehabilitation and resettlement census aims to identify and verify families affected by the trunk infrastructure component of the project.
- **Trunk Infrastructure:** The trunk infrastructure includes constructing the trunk road and related facilities, marking the first phase of the project, which is planned to extend until 2050 according to the draft Master Plan.

Great Nicobar Project

- **About:** The **Great Nicobar Island Project** is a major infrastructure initiative aimed at developing an international container transshipment port, airport, power infrastructure and greenfield township on Great Nicobar Island.
- **Project Cost:** The project is estimated at around **₹92,000 crore** and has a long-term timeline extending up to **2050**.
- **Key Components:** The draft Master Plan envisions transforming Great Nicobar into a greenfield township with a **tourism-based economy**, while also providing for defence infrastructure, an airport and an international transshipment container port.
- **Frontier Infrastructure:** The project has been described as a model for “frontier infrastructure development” in sensitive geographies, given Great Nicobar’s location close to critical sea lanes.
- **Strategic Importance:** The government has projected the project as important for strengthening India’s strategic presence in the Bay of Bengal and the wider **Indo-Pacific region**.
- **Concerns:** Concerns have been raised over the possible impact on indigenous communities, especially the **Nicobarese** and the **Shompen**, who have close cultural and ecological links with the island.
 - In 2024, the **Public Investment Board (Finance Ministry)** noted that the proposed Great Nicobar container port lacked clear strategic objectives, but recently, the Defence Ministry reaffirmed the project’s strategic importance for **national security and regional development**.

Source: 'Holistic Development of Great Nicobar Island at Andaman & Nicobar Islands': Pre-feasibility report (March 2021)



Read More: [NGT Approved Great Nicobar Project](#)

EAC-PM Recommendations on Delimitation



Source: TH

Recently, the **Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister (EAC-PM)** released a working paper on India's next **delimitation** of parliamentary constituencies.

- The paper recommends using **multi-factor criteria for a "targeted" splitting of seats**, going beyond population distribution while retaining the current proportion of Lok Sabha seats for large states.
- The study **used election data from 2009-2024** to estimate statistical relationships between **voter**

- **turnout, constituency size, and five “compositional features”:** urban share, SC share, ST share, linguistic polarisation, and linguistic diversity.
- The EAC-PM recommends that the Delimitation Commission use a constituency’s **demographic and linguistic profile, not size alone**, as the criterion for splitting, rather than applying a uniform rule.
- Delimitation should be timed with a **“fresh booth rationalisation cycle,” release of 2027 Census** tabulations, and gender-disaggregated electoral statistics to ensure accuracy and effectiveness.

Delimitation

- **About:** Delimitation is the process of **fixing or redrawing the boundaries of territorial constituencies for the Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies** to ensure that each seat represents a roughly equal number of voters.
- **Constitutional Mandate** : **Article 82** mandates Parliament to enact a Delimitation Act after each census, readjusting Lok Sabha seat allocation to States and dividing States into territorial constituencies.
 - **Article 170** provides for a similar readjustment of seats and constituencies in State Legislative Assemblies.
- **Delimitation Commission:** It is a high-powered, independent body appointed by the Central Government, consisting of **3 members, i.e., a Chairperson** (a serving or retired [Supreme Court Judge](#)), the **Chief Election Commissioner** (or an Election Commissioner nominated by them), and **State Election Commissioners** of the concerned states.
 - The orders of the Commission have the force of law and cannot be challenged in any court. Its orders are presented to the Lok Sabha and State Assemblies but cannot be modified.
 - It has been set up four times till March 2026, i.e., 1952, 1963, 1973, and 2002.
- **Freeze on Delimitation:** The **42nd Amendment Act, 1976** froze the total number of seats in the Lok Sabha on the 1971 Census to ensure that states implementing population control measures (primarily in the South) were not penalized with reduced political representation.
 - **84th Amendment Act, 2001** extended the freeze on the total number of seats until the first census after 2026.
 - While the 2002 Commission redrew internal boundaries within states (based on the 2001 Census), the inter-state allocation of seats remains based on 1971 data.

Read More: [Delimitation](#)

Supreme Court Quashes POCSO Conviction



Source: [TH](#)

Recently, the **Supreme Court** exercised its extraordinary powers under **Article 142 of the Constitution** to set aside the conviction of a man sentenced under the **Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, 2012**, noting that the victim had later married him after attaining majority.

POCSO Act 2012

- **Objective:** The law aims to **protect children (below 18 years) from sexual assault, sexual harassment and pornography**, and to provide **child-friendly procedures** for reporting and trial.
 - It was enacted in consequence to India's ratification of the **UN Convention on the Rights of the Child in 1992**.
- **Features:**
 - **Gender-Neutral Nature:** The Act recognises that both girls and boys can be victims of sexual abuse and that such abuse is a crime regardless of the gender of the victim.
 - **POCSO Rules, 2020:** The **POCSO Rules, 2020** strengthen implementation, providing child-friendly procedures, institutional safeguards, and mechanisms for reporting and trial.
 - **Confidentiality of Victim's Identity:** **Section 23 of the POCSO Act, 2012** mandates that the identity of child victims must be kept confidential. Media reports cannot disclose any details that could reveal the victim's identity, including their name, address, and family information.
 - **Mandatory Reporting of Child Abuse Cases:** **Sections 19 to 22** compel individuals who have knowledge or reasonable suspicion of such offences to report them to concerned authorities.
- **Punishments:** The Act prescribes graded punishments based on the severity of the offence. The **2019 amendment** introduced more stringent penalties, including **the death penalty for certain aggravated sexual offences** against children.

Read More: [POCSO Act](#)

Srishti Kiran Tops Global Under-13 Tennis Rankings

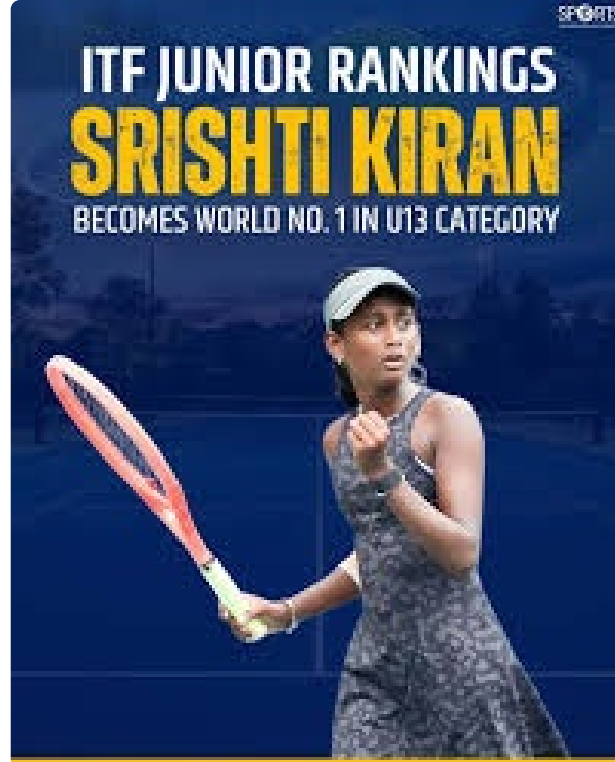


Srishti Kiran from Bengaluru achieved a historic milestone by becoming the **World No. 1 in the Under-13 category** in the **International Tennis Federation (ITF) Junior World Rankings**.

- Her rise was powered by **five consecutive ITF junior titles** and a runner-up finish at the **ITF World Tennis Tour Juniors J100 in Guatemala**.
- She also attained **ITF junior ranking of No. 357**, the highest among Under-13 players globally, despite competing in only **eight ranking tournaments**, **fewer than the ten tournaments considered for rankings**.
- **International Tennis Federation (ITF):** The ITF, founded in 1913, is the global governing body for tennis, wheelchair tennis, and beach tennis.
 - It administers and regulates the game, organizing international competitions like the **Davis Cup (men) and Billie Jean King Cup (women)**.
- **ITF World Tennis Tour:** The ITF acts as the transitional pathway between the junior circuit and the elite professional tours (ATP (Association of Tennis Professionals) for men and the WTA (Women's Tennis Association)).

The Grand Slams

- The four major tournaments, collectively known as the **Grand Slams**, are the absolute pinnacle of professional tennis.
 - **Australian Open** – Held in Melbourne; played on **hard courts**.
 - **French Open (Roland Garros)** – Held in Paris, the **only Grand Slam played on clay courts**.
 - **Wimbledon Championships** – Held in London; founded in **1877**, it is the **oldest tennis tournament in the world**. It is played on **grass courts** and is renowned for its strict **all-white dress code**.
- **US Open** – Held in New York City; played on **hard courts**.
- **Grand Slam Board:** Serves as the joint governance body of the four Grand Slam tournaments and the International Tennis Federation, coordinating rules and tournament administration.
- **Grand Slam Eligibility:** The four Grand Slam tournaments are open to internationally ranked players with a ranking of **500 or better**, based on merit and without discrimination. However, players **below 14 years of age** are ineligible.
- There is no limit on the number of Wild Cards a player may receive during their career.



Read more: [Leander Paes in Tennis Hall of Fame](#)